Prelude

THERE IS NOTHING SPECIALLY STRIKING ABOUT THE cluster of rocks which crowns the edge of a low hilly ridge near the village of Erragudi in the Andhra region of India. From a distance the cluster appears unremarkable, while the ridge on which it sits is somewhat bare, rising out of a patchwork of cultivated fields and sparsely dotted with vegetation. The rocks on it are not imposing, standing a mere thirty metres or so above the plains. It is what one sees on the rocks at close quarters that makes them spectacular.

Cascading down the rocks is a dramatic waterfall of words. More than a hundred lines in characters of the ancient Brahmi script are imprinted across several of the boulders (Fig. Prelude 2). Large portions of this ancient scrawl are even now exceedingly clear, the characters boldly etched across the rock faces. Some segments have deteriorated, while a few of the lines have been defaced by modern graffiti. Yet not even the English and Telugu scribbles of contemporary visitors to this hillock can diminish the overwhelming impression of messages from antiquity created by the profusion of these ancient words. This copious transcription on rocks is part of a royal enunciation. The words and phrases that comprise it were composed by and inscribed at the instructions of Ashoka (‘the sorrowless one’), the third emperor of the dynasty of the Mauryas—and the subject of this book.